



in the number of polio cases was noticed consequent to the NID strategy in 1995 and in the following years.

Since the campaign was launched by the Global Polio Eradication Initiative in 1988, more than two billion children around the world have been immunized against polio. The incidence of polio has since declined by more than 99 percent. The surveillance and laboratory network developed for polio eradication is one of the best and is often utilized by health workers for detecting other emerging infectious diseases such as yellow fever and measles. The visibility and popularity have led political leaders to increase budgets for polio immunization campaigns as well as other health programmes in several countries leading to improvements in public health efforts and infrastructures. According to Mr. Mahajan, at the start of the campaign in India, the contribution from Government and Donors used to be 20: 80 per cent where as for the past few years the contribution from Government has increased to 80 per cent and the rest are covered by Donors.

The campaign despite being one of the finest is struggling to eliminate the tail-end existence of the virus. The encouraging aspect, as per Polio experts is that the virus is now weakened and geographically restricted, with almost all of the cases confined to specific regions in Western U.P. and Bihar whereas the remaining of India is Polio-free. "It's no mean feat that out of 35 States in India, 33 enjoys the Polio-free status" says Mr. Kapur.

"Thanks to this massive immunization against Polio, today, Polio is endemic in just the four nations in the world – India, Pakistan, Afghanistan and Nigeria" said Mr. Ashok Mahajan Trustee of Rotary Foundation. Polio Eradication has created a culture of disease prevention, "prompting health workers and politicians to understand the benefits of preventing, rather than treating a disease", he added.

The polio eradication campaign is one of the largest such campaign in the country. With increasing immunity through Polio day and routine immunization, health experts believe that India is well on the track to eradicating the disease.

While the feasibility of polio eradication in the near-term was re-affirmed by global and national technical oversight bodies, the recommended intensification of supplementary immunization activities in the endemic countries, which includes India have significant financial implications. Recent funding by

organizations like Bill Gates, Google, Ms. Rajashree Birla of Aditya Birla Group and Ms. Usha and Laxmi Mittal of Arcelor&Mittal Steel, Rtn. Harshad Mehta and Rotary's own contribution along with the host country's finance has until now ensured the continuation of eradication activities without any hindrance and bridged the fund gap to an extent. According to senior Rotary member Mr. Raja Saboo, corporate houses in India must take part ownership of the national drive towards eradication of Polio as part of their CSR (Corporate Social Responsibility) to ensure that the eradication efforts against Polio is sustained and that the quality of the activities don't suffer because of lack of funds.

Low level of routine immunization, very low socio-economic status of populations in the densely populated regions of north India especially U.P and Bihar where high rate of malnutrition and unhygienic living conditions that favour Polio virus survival tends to undermine the gains made so far.

The extensive research that has helped in developing type-specific oral polio vaccines (OPV) monovalent (mOPV1 and mOPV3) and bivalent Oral Polio Vaccine (bOPV) are being used in this phase of eradication campaign. The national Polio surveillance unit (a joint collaboration between the GOI and WHO) reports that the introduction of mOPV1 in 2007 and 2008 in India has significantly brought down the incidence of P1 Polio strain, known to be the most virulent and threatening amongst the three strains of Polio virus. Also, the recently launched bOPV in India according to experts is a big boost in the fight against the remaining two strains of the virus. Their potent attack is expected to simultaneously bring down the incidence of Polio in India.

Further, in India the Political commitment towards polio eradication is quite strong with allocations of Rs. 1042 crore for the period 2009-2010 and Rs. 1290 crore in the year before. Indian Government is committed to completely eradicate Polio from India by 2012. The Indian Expert Advisory Group on Polio Eradication (IEAG), a think-tank of technical experts on Polio suggests that India is on track and close to the polio eradication target.

But, in this age of global mobility and increased human contact across borders, the ominous prospect of a reversal: the virus' re-transmission, overshadows the impressive milestone reached thus far. Trustee Ashok Mahajan clearly states, "Unless Polio is completely eradicated, a lone case of Polio can threat the well being of any child any where in the world".

- By H.K. Sethi

In India too, since the launch of the National Immunization Days, in 1995, the number of polio cases has reduced drastically almost by 99.5 % from 500 cases a day. As many as 4 million children have been saved from falling prey to Polio since the NID strategy was adopted in India. India's campaign against the virus is one of the best and biggest public health efforts in the country says Deepak Kapur, Chairman of Rotary's India Polio Committee